
Bellingham now a genuine doubt for World Cup 2026

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Bellingham now a genuine doubt for World Cup 2026

Thomas Tuchel insists he has “no problem” with Jude Bellingham. Why would he? But after leaving the Real Madrid star out of his England squad, Tuchel raised further doubts over the midfielder’s future ahead of the Three Lions’ clash with Wales on Thursday.

Tuchel cited [Bellingham’s](#) lack of rhythm having only just returned from shoulder surgery when asked why he hadn’t been included, but also claimed building “team spirit” was a factor in taking “a very straightforward decision to go with the same group of players” from the last international break, which included the 5-0 win over Serbia, the zenith of Tuchel’s reign.

And once again, in his pre-match press conference, the message of camaraderie was laid on with a trowel by Tuchel, who saw Steven Gerrard describing the Golden Generation as “egotistical losers” in conversation with Rio Ferdinand this week after they flopped at the 2006 World Cup.

“When I hear people talking about their titles in international football or their missed chances I hear always the same song: ‘We have been a team,’ or: ‘We haven’t been a team,’” Tuchel said. “I think the rivalry between clubs was huge in this moment and they obviously couldn’t find a way to buy into a bigger purpose, a bigger goal. A big, big opportunity wasted.”

Tuchel has Gareth Southgate to thank for expunging that inter-club rivalry, not that that should be an issue for Bellingham in any case, with him never having played in the Premier League.

But Tuchel is keenly aware, obsessed even, over the need for harmony among the players at a major tournament. And it’s becoming increasingly difficult not to make the connection between his decision to snub Bellingham and his bid to “make a talented team” like the New England Patriots.

“You need to accept your role and what being the best teammates is,” he said. “The only way we can make things happen at the World Cup is if we arrive with a strong team. I watched a documentary with the New England Patriots and there was a quote ‘don’t collect the best players, we make a talented team.’”

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The desire to get as many of the best players into the team as possible was a criticism aimed at Southgate, who played Phil Foden on the left at Euro 2024 over a more natural winger. And if Tuchel is to avoid the same mistake, there will be some absurdly talented No.10s on the bench and more watching from home.

While Tuchel will insist he’s not referring to anyone in particular, and that may very well be the case, the comments do feel pointed, coming as they do on the back of what has been quite the furore surrounding Bellingham’s absence, [the “repulsive” misunderstanding](#) and him being named England men’s player of the year for 2024-25.

Tuchel ploughed on: “We are not collecting the most talented players, we are trying to build a team. Teams win trophies, no one else. We will try to bring the best players and the best squad with the best players but it can sometimes happen in the end that you don’t just collect the most talented players and hope it works out.

“We build a team that cares for each other and supports each other, that accepts the hierarchy within the team, and this will bring us a long way.”

Whether the worry is over the effect of a bad apple or two on the squad, or the media and fan reaction to not selecting them, it consumes Tuchel.

And his words will surely be dominating Bellingham’s thoughts, which will previously have been focused on success as a leader for England in 2026 after the disappointment in 2024, but must now be plagued by doubts as to whether he will even be given that opportunity.

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